threat of an exodus, from leadership and cadre alike. Indiders in the Uddhav camp privately admit that the party may have alienated the core vote bank, which their founder, the late Bal Thackeray, had cultivated through an emphasis on aggressive Hindutva and Maratha pride. Association with the Congress's pro-minority politics brought it dividends in the Lok Sabha polls, but was always going to be a strain on its core identity. This dissatisfaction could be the unravelling of the MVA now.

The ripples now threaten the bloc in Parliament as well. Smaller INDIA allies have already signalled that they may not align with the Congress's priorities: the Adani issue, for instance, can imperil a few Opposition parties too. That ambivalence could spell fragmentation risks, undermining the alliance's ability to present a unified opposition to the BJP at the national level. "Let's not forget the BJP is still 32 seats short of a majority in the Lok Sabha. If the Opposition remains fixated on the INDIA bloc leader issue, the ruling party could push through contentious bills, despite lacking the numbers," warns a Congress MP. The Delhi election is up next and with both the Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) ruling out an alliance, it will be a litmus test of the former's ability to assert itself as the nucleus of anti-BJP politics.

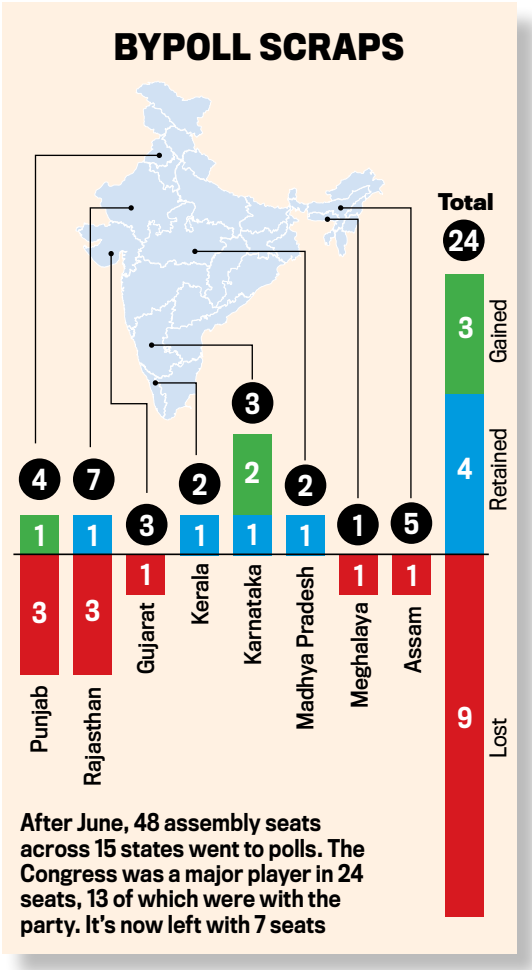
The False Dawn

The Congress's performance in the Lok Sabha election appeared to be the dawn of a revival, for the party secured 99 seats—nearly double its tally of 52 in 2019—and it briefly seemed as though it had found a way back to becoming relevant. The fact that it played a big role in reducing the BJP's tally from 303 seats in 2019 to a less-than-solo-majority 240 also boosted this narrative. But a closer look reveals that the Congress fed heavily off regional powerhouses such as the DMK (in Tamil Nadu), the SP (in Uttar Pradesh) and others. Of its 99 seats, 36 came from such states, benefiting more from strategic vote transfers than its own grassroots support.

More importantly, the Congress fared poorly in direct contests with the BJP, whether in head-to-head battles or in the presence of third parties. In 168 such contests, the Congress won just 30 seats. These numerical subtleties were papered over for a while, but soon came to light during the assembly polls since June, where the Congress strike rate in direct contests dropped to 20 per cent. This has given INDIA bloc partners more reasons to feel frustrated. In Maharashtra, the party faced the BJP in 75 seats but win only 10. In Haryana, it ceded victory to the BJP, while in J&K, the Congress won just six of the 32 seats it contested. Particularly striking was its dismal outing in Jammu, where it secured only one seat—the worst showing for the party in the region. "The Congress's failure to perform in Haryana and Maharashtra, after successfully challenging BJP in these states, points to a deeper structural problem," says Rahul Verma, fellow at the Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi.

To stay relevant, the Congress must pivot from national narratives to grassroots-level issues that resonate locally

The party's poor run continued even in the bypolls in 48 assembly seats across 15 states (see *Bypoll Scraps*). "The Congress fared better in the Lok Sabha by channelling public anger against the government through a compelling narrative.... But internally, the party's leadership and organisational structure remain unchanged. The BJP's course correction exposed these flaws," says a strategist associated with the party.



The Priyanka Promise

Despite the setbacks, the Congress appears to have little inclination to introspect and, instead, seems to have found solace in a few scattered bypoll successes, including two Lok Sabha poll victories—in Nanded (Maharashtra) and, most notably, in Wayanad, where the winner was Priyanka Gandhi Vadra. The party also won all three assembly seats in Karnataka, including two wrested from the BJP and JD(S) respectively. This has come as much-needed relief for the Congress-led Siddaramaiah government amid mounting allegations of corruption.

Meanwhile, Priyanka's entry into Parliament is being hailed as a landmark moment for the party, marking the first time that three members of the Gandhi family—Priyanka, brother Rahul and mother Sonia Gandhi—will serve together in Parliament. Her presence is expected to strengthen the Congress's voice, particularly on issues such as women's empowerment, social justice